Arolygiaeth Gofal Cymru
Care Inspectorate Wales

Inspection Report

Rhyd Hir

Neath

01792 817736

The inspection visit took place on 27/07/2026

Service Information:

Operated by:	National Autistic Society
Care Type:	Care Home Service Adults Without Nursing
Provision for:	Care home for adults - with personal care, Provision for learning disability
Registered places:	3
Main language(s):	English
Promotion of Welsh language and culture:	The provider makes an effort to promote the use of the Welsh language and culture or is working towards a bilingual service.

Ratings:

Well-being	Good
Care & Support	Good
Environment	Good
Leadership & Management	Good

Summary:

Rhyd Hir is a small care home located in a residential area on the outskirts of Neath. It caters for people with autism who may require personal care and support with daily activities. People can access community amenities using public transport or the home's own vehicle.

People receive good quality care and support which enhances their well-being and helps them lead healthy and fulfilled lives. People have opportunities to engage meaningfully with others and to expand their social and leisure experiences. Care staff know people very well and actively promote independence. People have timely access to medical and specialist services.

The home provides a comfortable and personalised living environment that meets people's needs and preferences. It is maintained to a good overall standard and has suitable facilities to promote independent living. People also benefit from regular environmental upgrades.

The service has an experienced manager who leads the home and staff team very effectively. People are cared for by motivated staff who are appropriately recruited, trained and supported. The organisation has recently appointed a new Responsible Individual (RI) and assistant director, who are making changes to improve operations. However, the RI must ensure the manager receives regular support and supervision, so expectations are clear and planned changes can be implemented successfully.

Findings:

Well-being — Good

People are very happy at Rhyd Hir, having lived there for many years. We observed people to be relaxed and content, singing and interacting positively with care staff as they went about their daily routines. People often spend time in the community and enjoy a range of fun and rewarding activities. They each have a new activity planner based on their preferred hobbies and interests. The service has recently established links with various community clubs, giving people more opportunities to expand their social circle and try new things. This has proved valuable in helping people adjust to changes in their routines after the closure of some day centre services. Care staff told us it is pleasing to see people broaden their interests and take joy from new experiences. Records confirm that people enjoy a variety of outings and mini-breaks to places of their choosing.

The service has effective systems in place to help keep people safe. People are regularly reminded about how to raise concerns, and they consistently report to feel safe during routine reviews. Care staff document incidents clearly, which key people within the organisation monitor remotely to ensure any necessary action is taken. People are cared for by staff who have been appropriately vetted and trained. Staff are up to date with safeguarding training and understand safeguarding and whistleblowing procedures well. There are robust systems in place to ensure the accommodation and facilities are safe and well-maintained.

People have control over their lives. Care staff present information thoughtfully and use various communication aids to help people make their own decisions. People are encouraged to complete domestic tasks independently and do so regularly. Care records identify the goals people want to achieve and reflect their personal views and preferences. People's cultural and religious needs are also accounted for. People do not currently require a service in Welsh, although they celebrate their culture and traditions through in-house activities and events.

The service helps people to maintain important relationships. People keep in touch with family and friends through regular phone calls and visits. Care staff keep people informed about contact arrangements and discuss them during reviews. People socialise with others through community-based activities. They have positive relationships with care staff and are supported by named keyworkers who help them plan for the future and review their care needs and goals. Care staff are kind, patient and respectful in their approach. They support people sensitively during difficult situations and understand how to engage with them in ways that reduce anxiety and distress.

The home has the facilities people need to support their activities of daily living. It is furnished and decorated to suit people's needs and interests. We observed people to be at ease in their surroundings, which are very familiar and comforting to them.

Care & Support — Good

People receive person-centred care and support. Care staff know people very well and plan care around their individual needs and preferences. Risk assessments and personal plans outline how care staff can safely support people to achieve their goals. These are regularly reviewed through monthly keyworker meetings and formal care reviews. Care recordings show that people live a healthy, independent lifestyle doing things they enjoy. The service is in the process of transferring care records to an electronic database. This will make records easier to access and provide more detailed information about people's care and support needs. The manager is also working with care staff to improve daily recordings, so they give a full and up to date picture of people's experiences.

The service manages medicines safely. Records show that people consistently receive their medicines at the prescribed times. Regular reviews are arranged, so medication can be adjusted in a timely way if needed. We saw that medicines are stored securely and at a suitable temperature. Care staff maintain clear records regarding the administration of medication and management of stock. All staff are up to date with their medication training.

People are supported to keep healthy. Information about their health needs is clearly recorded within health action plans and hospital passports. Care staff also use staff meetings to discuss the best strategies for helping people to eat well and stay active. They encourage and support people to plan and prepare nutritious meals and monitor their weight in line with personal plans. People receive routine health screens and input from various health services, including dentists, opticians, chiropodists, audiologists and other specialists. Care staff monitor people's health and well-being closely and support them to attend health appointments and reviews. They seek advice from professionals when needed and follow any advice given. People are given time to prepare for planned medical interventions, with correct procedures being followed to ensure these take place in people's best interests.

The service promotes good hygiene practices to minimise infection risks. We observed the home to be clean and tidy throughout. People contribute to the upkeep of their home by following cleaning rotas. They are also supported to receive the vaccinations they need and want to help protect them from infection. Care staff ensure sufficient cleaning supplies are available and undertake additional tasks to keep all areas and appliances clean. Staff complete mandatory and refresher training in relation to infection control.

Environment

Good

The location of the home enables people to connect easily with others. It neighbours a community of other care homes operated by the same provider, allowing people to join together for social events if they wish. People have their own bus passes or may use the home's vehicle to access the community with staff support. The service has recruited additional drivers, making it easier for staff to facilitate outings.

People live in a homely environment. Bedrooms are designed to meet people's needs and include personal touches that reflect their individuality. People are encouraged to make choices about how their home is decorated and furnished and can discuss any changes or purchases during keyworker meetings. The communal lounge is comfortably furnished and includes leisure items and other features people can identify with, such as personal photographs, homemade furnishings, sewing apparatus and home entertainment equipment. The home has outdoor facilities to support people to wash and dry their laundry. We saw that the grass lawns to the front and rear gardens are well tended. Managers are considering ways to enhance the outdoor space further, making it a more inviting area for people to use.

The provider continues to invest in the home to enhance its appearance and ensure it continues to meet people's needs. Since the last inspection, the communal toilet and shower room have been refurbished, and all bedrooms have been redecorated to reflect people's preferred styles. Other improvements include replastering ceilings in the ground floor hallway and lounge, laying a new driveway and purchasing new lounge furniture. The manager told us of plans to hang wallpaper in the lounge, which people will help choose. The office carpet is also due to be replaced.

The service manages risks to people's health and safety. We found that the accommodation and facilities are properly maintained. Suitable systems are in place to manage Legionella risks and records show that gas and electrical systems and fire safety equipment are working safely. Staff complete regular health and safety checks, which include window restrictors, water temperatures and fire equipment. The organisation has employed an additional maintenance officer since the last inspection, which means upgrades and repairs can be carried out more efficiently. A new system for requesting repairs has also been implemented, which is overseen by the assistant director. The manager confirmed that issues are addressed in a timely way, with urgent works being prioritised.

Leadership & Management — Good

The home has good leadership and management. The manager and staff team are adapting well to changes within the senior management team and the introduction of new administration systems. Staff told us the manager sets high standards by constantly putting people first and is extremely approachable and supportive. They said, *"I love that it's person-centred, they do a lot of stuff in the community"*, *"It's not all about working, it's about helping them to be independent"* and *"We communicate a lot here as a team... we manage as well as we can with all the changes"*. Service standards are monitored through formal RI visits and six-monthly quality reviews. Recent quality assurance reports reflect positively on people's experiences and the service's continued improvement and development.

The RI must ensure suitable arrangements are in place to support and supervise the manager. The manager is responsible for running three small care services but has not received formal supervision or an annual appraisal for a considerable period. As a result, previously set objectives have not been reviewed and revised in line with organisational changes. Failure to effectively supervise the manager puts people at risk of experiencing inconsistencies in day-to-day operations and may lead to the manager feeling undervalued. This requires improvement and we expect the provider to take action. The new RI and assistant director are committed to supporting the manager on a formal and informal basis. Since being appointed, the RI has made an initial visit to the service, and the assistant director has maintained weekly contact. The manager has also been invited to attend monthly management meetings. This support needs to continue, alongside formal supervision and appraisal, to ensure the manager is clear about ongoing priorities and has opportunities to discuss any personal or professional challenges.

People have experienced changes to staffing arrangements following the closure of some day centre services. The service is strengthening the team by recruiting additional staff, including a deputy manager who knows the home and can assist with managerial tasks. The staffing rota is also being restructured to better support people's new routines and funded hours of support while giving staff a more consistent work-life balance. These changes are expected to provide better stability to the service and support with embedding new systems of work.

Staff receive good quality training and support to undertake their roles effectively. They go through a safe recruitment process before being employed and apply to register with Social Care Wales, the workforce regulator, within six months. Staff develop their knowledge and skills through a comprehensive induction programme, ongoing training and peer support. Regular team meetings also give staff opportunities to discuss people's experiences and revisit the home's policies and procedures. We found staff to be motivated and passionate about their work, with records confirming they regularly receive meaningful supervision.

Areas identified for improvement

Where we identify **Areas for Improvement** but we have not found outcomes for people to be at immediate or significant risk, we discuss these with the provider. We expect the provider to take action and we will follow this up at the next inspection.

Where we find outcomes for people **require significant improvement** and/or there is risk to people's well-being we identify areas for **Priority Action**. In these circumstances we issue a Priority Action Notice(s) to the Provider, and they must take immediate steps to make improvements. We will inspect again within six months to check improvements have been made and outcomes for people have improved.

The table(s) below show the area(s) for priority action and/or those for improvement we have identified.

Summary of Areas for Improvement	Date identified
The Responsible Individual must supervise the management of the service effectively to ensure it operates safely and promotes the best possible outcomes for people. The manager must be supported to run the service safely, particularly through periods of change.	27/07/26

CIW has not issued any Priority action notices following this inspection.

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